CASE BRIEFING · FOR CLASSROOM & WORKSHOP DISCUSSION

The Cross-Functional Transition: Resolving Handoff Friction

How one manufacturer's forecasting gap between commercial sales and operations became a leadership problem, and what a cross-functional intervention changed. Written for discussion in execution-focused management development programmes.

AUDIENCE	Operations directors, supply chain leaders, L&D partners and MDP facilitators
USE	Teaching case with discussion questions, analysis framework and facilitator notes
PAIRS WITH	Customised MDP Accelerator: 6-Week Diagnostic & Delivery Blueprint (Modules 3-4)

Illustrative teaching case. The company, people and figures are fictional and written for classroom discussion. This case does not describe a TAPMI client or a real engagement.

TEACHING CASE · FICTIONAL COMPANY

SETTING

1. Arqen Precision Systems

Arqen Precision Systems is a fictional mid-size manufacturer of industrial motion components, supplying equipment makers across south India from one plant outside Bengaluru. Revenue is growing, the order book is healthy, and the plant is quietly failing to keep its promises.

Arqen sells configured products with 6-10 week quoted lead times. The commercial team wins orders by being flexible on dates and specifications. Operations absorbs that flexibility as chaos: forecast accuracy has drifted, expediting is routine, and the plant runs hot one month and idle the next. Both functions are competent. Both hit their own numbers. The company misses its delivery commitments anyway.

The cast

- **Meera Kulkarni, VP Sales.** Ten years at Arqen, owns the top line. Believes forecasts are a planning aid, not a commitment, because customers change their minds.

- **Dev Nair, Head of Operations.** Built the plant's quality record. Believes sales sells dreams and leaves the factory to pay for them.
- **Rafiq Sheikh, Plant Manager.** Caught in the middle; his schedulers rebuild the plan every Monday around the latest commercial surprise.
- **Anita Rao, Head of L&D.** Has watched two rounds of generic leadership training come and go with no change on the shop floor.

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THE TRIGGER

2. The order that slipped

In the second quarter, a anchor customer escalated after a flagship order shipped five weeks late. The post-mortem was uncomfortable for everyone. Sales had logged the order at the customer's requested date without a capacity check. Operations had seen the risk three weeks earlier but raised it in a meeting sales did not attend. The plant had quietly re-sequenced twice, burning overtime and upsetting two other customers whose orders were bumped.

No individual had made a bad decision. Every handoff between them had failed: information existed in one function that another function needed, and there was no shared routine, no shared number and no shared owner for moving it. The escalation cost Arqen a penalty, a discount on the next order, and a strain on its most important account.

> **DISCUSSION QUESTION 1**
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> Map the handoffs in this story: forecast to plan, order to schedule, risk to decision. At which exact point did each one break, and who owned that point?

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THE INTERVENTION

3. What changed

Anita argued that this was not a skills problem to fix with another generic course. With the leadership team's backing, a cross-functional group of eight middle managers, two each from sales, operations, planning and finance, went through an execution-focused development programme built around Arqen's own live problem instead of imported cases.

The group's diagnosis reframed the issue: the forecasting gap was a decision-rights problem wearing a data problem's clothes. Sales had no obligation to commit to a forecast; operations had no authority to challenge an order's date; nobody owned the number in between. Their proposal, defended in front of Meera, Dev and the CFO:

- **One shared demand number.** A single rolling forecast reviewed in one weekly 30-minute meeting with both functions present, replacing separate sales and operations versions.
- **A handoff protocol.** Orders above a size threshold require a capacity check before a date is promised; date changes after confirmation follow a written escalation path with a named owner.
- **Service-level review measures.** Promise-keeping, forecast accuracy and expediting hours tracked on one page, reviewed monthly by both function heads together.
- **Rotating chair.** The weekly review alternates between commercial and operations chairs so neither function owns the truth.

In the case's fictional epilogue, promise-keeping recovers over two quarters and expediting hours fall by roughly a third. The numbers are illustrative; the mechanism, shared facts, explicit decision rights and a routine that forces the conversation, is the point.

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ANALYSIS

4. Discussion framework

For participant groups

> **DISCUSSION QUESTIONS**
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> 2. Meera and Dev are both right about their own function. What makes cross-functional conflict rational even when everyone is competent and well-intentioned?
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> 3. The diagnosis called this a decision-rights problem, not a data problem. Do you agree? What evidence in the case supports or undermines that reading?
>
> 4. Which element of the proposal would be hardest to implement in your own organisation, and why: the shared number, the capacity check, the escalation path or the rotating chair?
>
> 5. Anita chose a programme built around a live internal problem over open-enrolment courses. What does that choice buy, and what does it risk?

Facilitator notes

- Push groups past "better communication" toward structure: decision rights, shared metrics and routines are what survive a busy quarter.
- Use the handoff map from question 1 as the anchor artefact; most groups find the break at order-to-schedule and underestimate how early the risk was visible.
- Connect to Module 3 (cross-functional execution) and Module 4 (execution under uncertainty) of the MDP blueprint: the case rehearses exactly the influence-without-authority and shared-accountability moves those modules teach.
- The fictional epilogue's improvement is deliberately partial. Groups that discuss why the remaining two thirds of expediting did not disappear get the most from the case.

Illustrative teaching case prepared by a student project team for academic evaluation in the Business Marketing course at TAPMI Bengaluru. Fictional company, people and figures; not a description of a real client or engagement.